

Sengol in New NCERT Textbook



Source: TH

Why in News?

The '**Sengol**' , which was **installed in the new Parliament building in 2023** , has been featured in the newly released NCERT class 9 textbook, titled *Understanding Society and Beyond – Part 2* . The textbook links it to the **Chola tradition of righteous governance** and the **transfer of power in 1947** .

What is the Historical and Cultural Significance of the Sengol?

- **Symbol of Righteousness:** The word 'Sengol' is derived from the Tamil word '**semmai**' , which means righteousness. It fundamentally represents just and fair governance by a ruler, standing in direct contrast to '**Kodungol**' , which signifies authoritarianism or unjust rule.
 - In ancient Tamil tradition, the Sengol was viewed primarily as a profound virtue or concept of equity rather than just a decorated rod. It served as a constant reminder to the king that he held the "**aanai**" (decree) to govern fairly and uphold his duties to the people.
- **Prominence in Classical Literature:**
 - **Silappadikaram (was written by the poet and prince Ilango Adigal):** The first Tamil epic highlights its importance when Chera King Cheran Senguttuvan praises a Pandiyan king for sacrificing his own life to restore the "**uprightness of the Sengol**" after mistakenly executing an innocent man.
 - **Tirukkural (authored by Thiruvalluvar):** Dedicates an entire chapter to '**Sengonmai**' (The Right Sceptre), emphasising that a ruler's equity, not his weapons, brings true victory.
 - **Sangam Era Texts:** The practice of using a sceptre to denote righteous rule finds mention in **2,000-year-old texts like Purananooru , Kurunthogai , and Tholkappiyam** .
- **Integral to Coronation Rites:** Historically associated with the Chola dynasty and Nayaka kings, the Sengol was handed to a new monarch by high priests during coronation ceremonies.
 - It was recognized as a sacred symbol marking the transfer of power and the bestowment of ethical responsibility.
- **A Core Pillar of the Kingdom:** Ancient Tamil treatises classify the Sengol as one of the 10 essential constituents of a kingdom, standing alongside other symbols of sovereignty like the *venkottra kudai* (white umbrella) and *murasu* (drum).

Sengol Connection to India's Independence in 1947

- Freedom fighter **C. Rajagopalachari (Rajaji)** suggested to **Jawaharlal Nehru** that the Sengol be used as a ceremonial symbol to mark the **transfer of power from British rule to independent India**.
- **Rajaji approached the Thiruvavaduthurai Adheenam** , a 14th-century Saivaite Math in Tamil Nadu, which commissioned a **gold-plated silver Sengol topped with a Nandi** .
- On **14 th August 1947** , the Sengol was brought to Delhi, **first presented to Lord Mountbatten** , **sanctified with holy water, and then ceremonially handed over to Jawaharlal Nehru** .
 - The ceremony symbolised the **transfer of power from British rule to independent India** , along with the **ethical responsibility associated with authority** .
- The **Sengol** , installed in the new Parliament building in **2023** , is topped with a **Nandi** , which symbolises **steadfast justice, firmness, and the vigilant observance of truth (Nyaya)** .



Other Ancient Governance Concepts Highlighted in the New NCERT Textbook

- **Institutional Mottos:** The textbook links *India's national motto, Satyameva Jayate, to the Mundaka Upanishad*, noting that it replaced the British-era motto *"Heaven's Light, Our Guide."*
 - Similarly, the **Supreme Court's motto, Yato Dharmastato Jayah** ("Where there is righteous duty, there is victory"), is linked to the **Mahabharata** .
- **Ram Rajya:** The text cites Mahatma Gandhi's reference to **Ram Rajya** (drawing from the Ramayana and the 16 th -century **Ramcharitmanas**) as an ideal governance structure based on probity, transparency, compassion, and public welfare.
- **Governance as a 'Sacred Responsibility':** It asserts that from the Vedic period through the eras of the Ramayana and Mahabharata, Indian traditions viewed **governance as a sacred duty to the people, rather than merely a mechanism for exercising power.**
- **Divine Validation of Resistance:** In the chapter titled 'Resistance and Resilience,' the text highlights traditional beliefs where Indian kings received swords from Goddesses (such as Kali, Durga, and Bhavani) to resist foreign invasions.
 - Examples cited include **Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj receiving a sword from Goddess Tulja Bhavani and Kumara Kampana** using a goddess-given sword against Sultanate forces.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is Sengol?

The **Sengol is a ceremonial sceptre associated with righteous governance** , derived from Tamil traditions and linked to the symbolic transfer of power in **1947** .

2. What does the Sengol symbolise?

It symbolises **just and ethical rule** , where political authority is accompanied by a responsibility to govern fairly.

3. What is the significance of Satyameva Jayate?

Satyameva Jayate , meaning "Truth alone triumphs," comes from the **Mundaka Upanishad** and is India's national motto.

4. What is the meaning and source of Yato Dharmastato Jayah?

Yato Dharmastato Jayah means **"Where there is righteous duty, there is victory"** and is associated with the **Mahabharata** .

5. What is Ram Rajya in the context of governance?

Ram Rajya is presented as an **ideal of good governance** , associated with **probity, transparency, compassion and public welfare** .

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. Which of the following statements on the Amaravati Stupa and its relief sculpture is/are correct? (2026)

1. It was located in the lower Krishna valley.
2. In India, it was next only to the Sanchi Stupa in size.
3. The Amaravati school of sculpture made a lasting impact on the later South Indian sculpture, and its products were carried to Sri Lanka and South-east Asia.

Select the answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: B

Mains

Q. Chola architecture represents a high watermark in the evolution of temple architecture. Discuss. (2013)

Swachh Bharat Mission-Gramin



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Swachh Bharat Mission-Grameen (SBM-G)** has evolved from a toilet construction programme into a broader **community-led sanitation movement** focused on **behaviour change, waste management and sustainable sanitation systems** .

What is Swachh Bharat Mission-Gramin (SBM-G)?

- The **Swachh Bharat Mission-Grameen (SBM-G)** was launched on **2nd October 2014** with the objective of **making rural India Open Defecation Free (ODF)** by providing access to toilets and promoting behavioural change.
- **Phase I: SBM-G (2014-2019)**
 - Phase I focused on **eliminating open defecation and achieving universal sanitation coverage in rural areas**.
 - **Achievements:**
 - Over 100 million individual household toilets were constructed.
 - More than 6 lakh villages were declared ODF by October 2019.
 - The Mission contributed to achieving SDG Target 6.2 on sanitation and hygiene.
 - It also improved health, safety and dignity, particularly for women, while reducing environmental contamination associated with open defecation.
- **Phase II: SBM-G (2020-21 to 2025-26)**
 - After achieving ODF status, Phase II shifted the focus from **toilet construction to sustaining ODF outcomes** and achieving comprehensive sanitation.
 - **Key Objectives**
 - **Sustaining ODF Status:** Prevent slippage into open defecation and ensure continued toilet usage and maintenance.
 - **Solid Waste Management** : Establish systems for household waste collection, segregation, processing and disposal, including management of plastic waste.
 - **Liquid Waste Management:** Promote effective management of greywater and other liquid waste through appropriate drainage and wastewater-management systems.
 - **Visual Cleanliness:** Ensure minimal litter, stagnant wastewater and plastic waste dumps in public places.
- **ODF Plus Categories:** The progress of villages under SBM-G Phase II is assessed through three categories:

Category	Criteria
Aspiring	Sustaining ODF status + arrangement for either solid or liquid waste management
Rising	Sustaining ODF status + arrangements for both solid and liquid waste management
Model	Sustaining ODF status + both waste-management systems + visual cleanliness + ODF Plus IEC messages

- **GOBARdhan (Galvanizing Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan):** A flagship umbrella initiative under SBM-G Phase II that converts cattle dung, agricultural crop residue, and organic waste into biogas, compressed bio-gas (CBG), and organic manure/bio-slurry.



What is the Significance of SBM-G?

- Behaviour Change Communication (BCC):** SBM-G has shifted the focus from mere toilet construction to **sustained sanitation behaviour** .
 - It promotes **safe toilet usage, hygiene practices, handwashing, safe water storage, waste segregation, composting and responsible disposal practices** to ensure long-term sanitation outcomes.
- Women as Sanitation Change Agents:** Women have emerged as active participants in sanitation transformation through **Swachhagrahis and Self-Help Groups (SHGs)** .
 - They promote toilet usage, conduct awareness campaigns, support waste management and strengthen community-level sanitation practices.
- Role of Schools in Sanitation Awareness:** Schools act as centres for developing sanitation habits among children by **promoting hygiene education, waste management and environmental responsibility**.
 - Initiatives under SBM-G encourage students to carry sanitation practices from schools to their families and communities.
- Community Institutions and Local Governance: Gram Panchayats and Village Water and Sanitation Committees (VWSCs)** provide institutional support for sustainable sanitation through village planning, waste management, IEC activities and community mobilisation.
 - They connect individual sanitation practices with collective village-level outcomes.
- Jan Bhagidari and Citizen Participation:** Cleanliness has evolved into a people-led movement through initiatives such as **Swachhata Hi Seva (SHS)** , which encourages participation of citizens, SHGs, youth groups, schools and local institutions in maintaining public cleanliness.
- Sanitation and Livelihood Generation:** SBM-G has created new livelihood opportunities in **waste collection, recycling, composting, sanitation infrastructure and maintenance services**.
 - Women-led enterprises and community groups are increasingly participating in waste management activities.
- Waste-to-Wealth through Circular Economy:** Initiatives like **GOBARdhan** promote the conversion of organic waste, cattle dung and agricultural residue into **biogas, compressed bio-gas (CBG) and organic manure** , supporting sustainable waste management and rural livelihoods.
- Sustainable Sanitation through Resource Recovery:** Community-led models such as greywater

treatment demonstrate how sanitation can contribute to **water conservation, groundwater recharge, irrigation support and environmental sustainability** .

What Concerns Remain in India’s Sanitation Push, and What Measures are Needed to Address Them?

Concerns	Measures Needed
Sustaining ODF and Hygiene: Preventing slippage into open defecation and ensuring continued toilet use, handwashing and safe water practices remain important.	Sustained Behaviour Change: Strengthen BCC through Swachhagrahis, SHGs, schools and community participation to maintain sanitation and hygiene practices.
Solid and Plastic Waste Management: Gaps in waste collection, segregation, processing and disposal can undermine rural cleanliness.	Decentralised Waste Management: Strengthen village-level collection, segregation, recycling, composting and scientific disposal systems.
Liquid Waste Management: Poor greywater and wastewater management can cause stagnant water and environmental contamination.	Greywater Management: Promote drainage, treatment, reuse, water conservation and groundwater recharge through locally appropriate solutions.
Weak Local Institutional Capacity: Gram Panchayats need sustained capacity for sanitation planning, monitoring and maintenance.	Empower Local Institutions: Strengthen their technical, financial and managerial capacity and integrate sanitation into village development planning.
Limited Livelihood Opportunities: Sanitation infrastructure requires continuous operation and maintenance, while waste remains an underutilised resource.	Sanitation-Based Circular Economy: Expand GOBARdhan, recycling, composting and waste-to-energy models , while promoting women-led enterprises and SHGs .
Need for Community Ownership: Sanitation outcomes depend on sustained participation beyond government-led infrastructure creation.	Deepen Jan Bhagidari: Involve citizens, SHGs, youth, schools and local institutions through initiatives such as Swachhata Hi Seva to sustain community-led sanitation.

Conclusion

India’s sanitation journey has progressed through three stages: Access → **Usage** → **Sustainability** . SBM-G has transformed sanitation from a government programme focused on infrastructure creation into a **people-led movement based on behavioural change, community ownership and sustainable waste management** .

Drishti Mains Practice Questions

Swachh Bharat Mission-Grameen has evolved from a toilet construction programme into a sustainable sanitation movement. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. What is Swachh Bharat Mission-Grameen (SBM-G)?

SBM-G is a rural sanitation mission launched in 2014 to improve sanitation coverage, eliminate open defecation and promote sustainable waste management.

Q2. When was SBM launched?

Swachh Bharat Mission was launched on **2 October 2014**.

Q3. What was the rural sanitation coverage at the launch of SBM?

Rural sanitation coverage was around **39% in 2014**.

Q4. When was rural India declared ODF?

Rural India was declared **Open Defecation Free (ODF) in 2019**.

Q5. What is the focus of SBM-G Phase II?

SBM-G Phase II focuses on sustaining ODF outcomes and strengthening Solid and Liquid Waste Management systems.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/IBb733zdSzl>]

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Mains :

Q. “To ensure effective implementation of policies addressing the water, sanitation and hygiene needs the identification of the beneficiary segments is to be synchronized with anticipated outcomes.” Examine the statement in the context of the WASH scheme. **(2017)**

Q. How could social influence and persuasion contribute to the success of Swachh Bharat Abhiyan? **(2016)**

Q. What are the impediments in disposing the huge quantities of discarded solid waste which are continuously being generated? How do we remove safely the toxic wastes that have been accumulating in our habitable environment? **(2021)**

India's Pharmaceutical Price Regulation



Source: IE

Why in News?

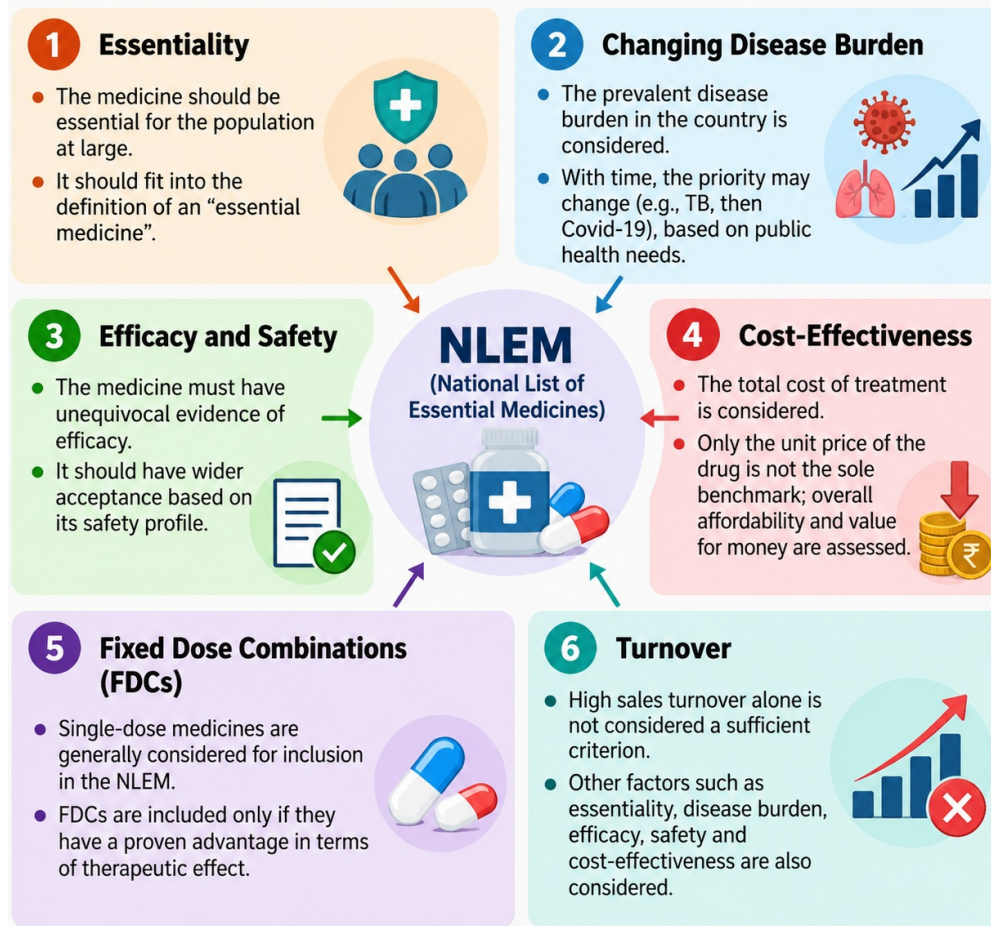
The **Supreme Court of India** criticized the massive markup between the wholesale price and the Maximum Retail Price (MRP) of essential life-saving medicines. Terming a 10-fold markup on a **cancer** drug as "broad daylight dacoity", the Court questioned the Union Government on why a **uniform retailer margin** should not be applied to all essential medicines and medical devices.

How is the Pharmaceutical Sector Regulated in India?

Regulation of Pricing

- **Essential Commodities Act, 1955 (ECA):** Medicines are declared essential commodities, empowering the government to control their production, supply, and pricing.
- **Drugs (Prices Control) Order, 2013 (DPCO):** Issued under the **ECA (1955)** , it provides the legal framework for drug price control in India.
- **National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA):** An independent body under the **Department of Pharmaceuticals (Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers)** . It regulates prices, enforces the **DPCO** , and recovers overcharges from companies.
 - **Scheduled Drugs:** Medicines listed in the **National List of Essential Medicines (NLEM)** . Currently, the NLEM 2022 includes 388 medicines and about 1,000 formulations.
 - The NPPA calculates the ceiling price based on the simple average of the **Price to Retailer (PTR) of all brands holding at least a 1% market share.**
 - A fixed 16% notional retailer margin is added to this average to cap the final MRP. Annual revisions are strictly pegged to the **Wholesale Price Index (WPI).**
 - **Non-Scheduled Drugs:** For medicines outside the NLEM, manufacturers can fix the launch price but cannot increase the MRP by more than **10% annually** .
 - Because the launch price is un-capped, companies build in massive Trade Margins (the gap between ex-factory cost/PTR and MRP) to incentivize distributors, chemists, and corporate hospitals to push their specific brands.

Criteria for a Medicine to be Included in the National List of Essential Medicines (NLEM)



Regulation of Quality and Manufacturing

- **Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940:** Regulates the import, manufacture, distribution, and sale of drugs and cosmetics.
- **Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO):** The apex regulatory body under the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare**. It is responsible for the approval of new drugs, conduct of clinical trials, and laying down standards for drugs.

What are the Key Concerns Regarding the Regulation of India’s Pharma Sector?

- **Exorbitant Trade Margins:** Because launch prices of non-scheduled drugs (which form 80% of the market) are unregulated, pharmaceutical companies offer massive trade margins (often over 500-1000%) to incentivize corporate hospitals, distributors, and chemists to push their specific brands.
- **Information Asymmetry & Captive Consumers:** Patients lack pharmacological awareness to question doctors or ask for identical, cheaper generic equivalents.
 - In corporate hospitals, patients are "**captive buyers**" forced to buy in-house pharmacy drugs billed at the maximum printed MRP.
- **Medicines Driving Catastrophic Out-of-Pocket Expenditure (OOPE):** The failure to effectively control drug prices is the primary driver of India's healthcare financial burden.
 - According to **National Health Accounts (NHA) estimates for 2022-23**, Out-of-Pocket Expenditure (OOPE) accounts for a staggering **43.4% of Total Health Expenditure (THE)** in India.
 - More alarmingly, **NSSO (75th Round) data** indicates that **medicines alone account for roughly**

70% of all out-of-pocket healthcare expenses .

- **Quality Control & Spurious Drugs:** The divided regulatory mechanism between **CDSCO (Centre)** and **SDRAs (States)** leads to uneven enforcement of quality standards.
 - The World Health Organisation (WHO) has raised concerns over substandard Indian cough syrups contaminated with diethylene glycol and ethylene glycol, which have been linked to around 300 child deaths, highlighting gaps in pharmaceutical quality control.
- **Narrow Scope of NLEM:** The NLEM covers only about **20% of the total pharmaceutical market turnover**, leaving the vast majority of critical and rare-disease drugs out of the strict ceiling price net.
- **Violation of the Right to Health:** Allowing manufacturers unrestricted power to set initial MRPs, regardless of actual manufacturing costs, is argued to be a violation of **Article 21 of the Constitution (Right to Life)**.

India's Initiatives to Ensure Affordable and Quality Medicines

- **Trade Margin Rationalisation (TMR):** The NPPA has successfully invoked its extraordinary powers to cap the trade margins of critical medical items. This led to drastic price drops for **42 anti-cancer medicines**, coronary stents, orthopaedic knee implants, and oxygen concentrators.
- **Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana (PMBJP):** A flagship scheme providing high-quality generic medicines at prices 50% to 80% cheaper than branded counterparts through dedicated Jan Aushadhi Kendras.
- **National Health Mission (NHM):** The Free Drugs Service Initiative under NHM, provides essential medicines free of cost at public health facilities from Primary Health Centres (PHCs) to district hospitals.
- **Pharma Sahi Daam App:** Launched by the NPPA to empower consumers to check the prices of medicines, find generic substitutes, and register complaints against overcharging.
- **Mandatory Schedule M (Good Manufacturing Practices):** The government has revised "Schedule M" rules, making **World Health Organization (WHO) standard Good Manufacturing Practices (GMP)** mandatory for all pharmaceutical MSMEs to ensure stringent quality control.

Way Forward

- **Universal Trade Margin Capping:** Instead of just capping the absolute prices of NLEM drugs, the government must impose a strict cap on the maximum permissible trade margin across the *entire* pharmaceutical supply chain to curb "hospital-driven" pricing.
- **Achieving API Sovereignty:** India must aggressively operationalize its **Bulk Drug Parks**, providing cheap electricity, effluent treatment **subsidies**, and **tax holidays** to enable **Indian API manufacturers** to compete with Chinese economies of scale.
- **Diplomatic and Market Diversification:** Indian pharma must diversify its export markets beyond the US and EU, while the government must use free trade agreements (FTAs) to safeguard against arbitrary international tariffs and export bans.
- **Enforcing Generic Prescriptions:** Strict penal enforcement of the **National Medical Commission**

- (NMC) guidelines, which legally mandate doctors to prescribe medicines by their generic pharmacological names rather than brand names.
- **Centralised Quality Regulation:** India must move towards a unified, centralized drug regulatory framework (merging State and Central licensing powers) to ensure zero-tolerance quality enforcement across all manufacturing units.

Drishti Mains Question:

“Affordable medicines are essential for achieving universal health coverage.” Examine the challenges in India’s pharmaceutical price-regulation framework.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the DPCO, 2013?

The **Drugs (Prices Control) Order, 2013** , issued under the Essential Commodities Act, provides the framework for regulating prices of medicines in India.

2. What is the role of NPPA?

The **National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority** fixes and monitors drug prices, enforces DPCO provisions and recovers overcharged amounts.

3. How are prices of scheduled drugs determined?

For NLEM-listed medicines, the ceiling price is generally based on the **average Price to Retailer (PTR) of qualifying brands** , with the prescribed retailer margin added.

4. What is PMBJP?

Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana provides affordable generic medicines through **Jan Aushadhi Kendras** , helping reduce patients’ medicine expenditure.

5. Why is Schedule M important?

Schedule M prescribes Good Manufacturing Practices (GMP) for pharmaceutical manufacturing and aims to strengthen medicine quality, safety and consistency.

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Q. How is the Government of India protecting traditional knowledge of medicine from patenting by pharmaceutical companies? (2019)

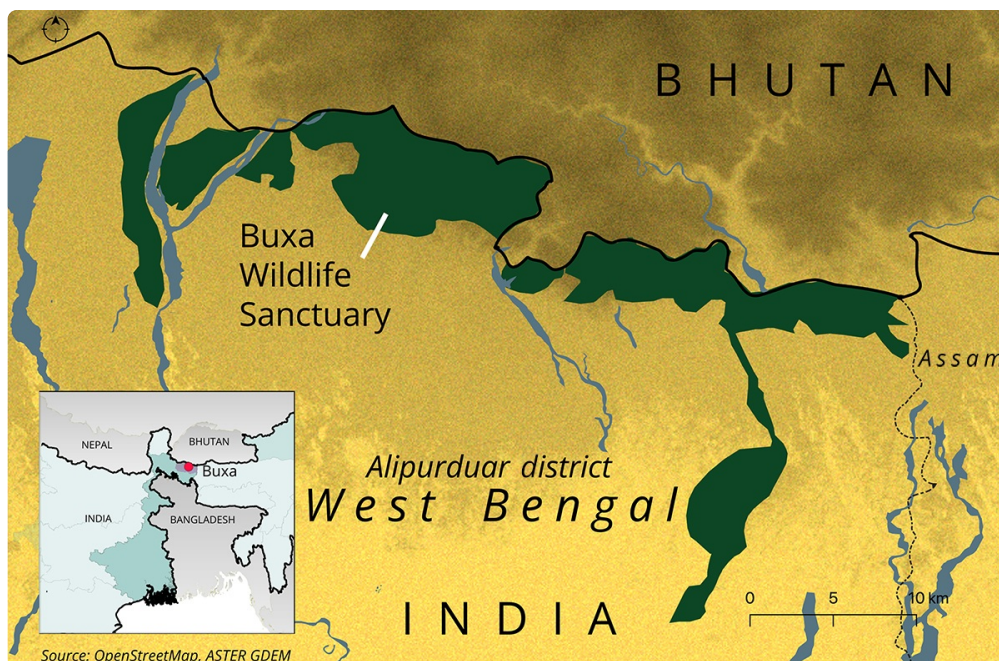
Q. What do you understand by Fixed Dose Drug Combinations (FDCs)? Discuss their merits and demerits. (2013)



Source: IE

In a major milestone for species conservation, a **tigress (T138)** translocated from **Valmiki Tiger Reserve (Bihar)** was released into **Buxa Tiger Reserve (West Bengal)** to inaugurate **India's Wildlife Week 2026** and initiate a phased tiger recovery programme.

- India's Wildlife Week 2026 is observed nationwide from 2 nd October to 8 th October to promote biodiversity conservation and public awareness. India's Wildlife Week 2026 central theme, "**Connecting Habitats, Thriving Wildlife**," emphasizes the critical necessity of ecological corridors for species survival and safe dispersal.
- **Institutional Architecture:** The reintroduction is part of the **Tiger Augmentation and Recovery Project** , implemented collaboratively since **2018** by the **Government of West Bengal** , the **National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA)** , and the **Wildlife Institute of India (WII)** .
- **Phased Translocation & Monitoring:** Translocated under standard NTCA veterinary and management protocols, the tigress will be tracked using **radio telemetry** , **camera traps** , and field-based observation, with plans to introduce **three additional tigers** to establish a viable breeding population.
- **Buxa Tiger Reserve (BTR):** Located in **Alipurduar district, West Bengal** , BTR covers **Terai, Bhabar and sub-Himalayan ecosystems** along the Bhutan and Assam borders.
 - Buxa forms a critical transboundary landscape with a contiguous corridor. It connects the **North East and Brahmaputra Valley tiger landscape** with **Manas Tiger Reserve (Assam)** , **Phipsoo Wildlife Sanctuary (Bhutan)** and **Jaldapara National Park (West Bengal)** , facilitating natural genetic exchange and wildlife dispersal.
 - The rivers **Sankosh, Raidak, Jayanti, Churnia, Turturi, Phashkhawa, Dima, and Nonani** flow through Buxa National Park.
 - BTR is rich in **Sal, Champ and Simul forests** and supports **tigers, elephants, gaurs, sambar, wild dogs and wild boars** , along with endangered species such as the **Bengal florican and Chinese pangolin** .
 - Addressing the historical absence of resident tigers caused by prey depletion, authorities restored over **380 hectares of grasslands** and released more than **800 chital (Axis axis)** to ensure adequate carrying capacity before releasing the apex predator.



Read more: [Project Tiger](#)

KAZIND 2026



Source: AIR

A 60-member **Indian Armed Forces contingent** is participating in the **9th edition of the India-Kazakhstan Joint Military Exercise, KAZIND 2026** , being held in Oskemen, Kazakhstan, from 28th September to 11th October 2026.

- **Objective:** Enhance **interoperability and joint counter-terrorism capabilities** in a **sub-conventional environment under a UN mandate** .
- **Operational Focus:** Semi-urban and mountainous terrain, including:
 - Air mobility
 - UAS and Counter-UAS operations
 - Cordon-and-search operations
 - Raids and search-and-destroy missions
 - Special Heliborne Operations
- **India-Kazakhstan Relations:**
 - **Diplomatic Relations:** Established in **1992** ; India was among the early countries to recognise independent Kazakhstan.
 - **Strategic Partnership:** Bilateral relations were elevated to a **Strategic Partnership in 2009** .
 - **Central Asian Engagement:** Kazakhstan is an important partner in India's **Connect Central Asia** approach and participates in the **India-Central Asia Dialogue** .
 - **Multilateral Cooperation:** Both countries cooperate through the **SCO, UN and CICA** .
 - **UNSC:** Kazakhstan has supported **India's candidature for permanent membership of an expanded UN Security Council** .
 - **Defence Cooperation:** Based on the **2015 Agreement on Defence and Military Technical Cooperation** , covering military training, exercises, education and military-technical cooperation.
 - **Connectivity:** Both countries cooperate on the **Chabahar Port** initiative, providing India with a potential connectivity route to Central Asia.

Read more: [India-Central Asia Relations](#)

GOBARdhan Scheme



Source: TH

The **GOBARdhan scheme** seeks to significantly expand India's **Compressed Biogas (CBG)** production by converting agricultural and organic waste into a source of clean domestic energy.

GOBARdhan (Galvanizing Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan)

- **Launch:** 2018, under the **Swachh Bharat Mission-Grameen (SBM-G)** framework.
- **Nodal Ministry:** Ministry of Jal Shakti, through the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation (DDWS) for its SBM-G component.
- **Core Objective:** Convert cattle dung and other biodegradable waste into useful resources such as:
 - Biogas
 - Compressed Bio-Gas (CBG)
 - Bio-slurry/organic manure
- **Feedstock:** Animal dung, crop residue, kitchen/food waste and other organic waste.
- **GOBARdhan under SBM-G Phase II:**
 - GOBARdhan is an **important component of Solid Waste Management under SBM-G Phase II**, supporting villages in converting biodegradable waste into biogas and bio-slurry.
 - Financial assistance of up to **₹50 lakh per district** is available for community and **cluster-level biogas plants** under **SBM-G Phase II** for the programme period 2020-21 to 2026-27.
 - It **encourages Gram Panchayats and local institutions** to participate in decentralised waste-to-energy solutions.
- **Economic and Environmental Impact:** It seeks to scale up Compressed Bio-Gas (CBG) production **10-fold, while converting agricultural and organic waste into domestic energy. It is expected to save over ₹40,000 crore in fuel imports, add more than ₹75,000 crore to GDP**, and generate over 1.5 lakh jobs.
- **Significance for Farmers:** By converting agricultural and organic waste into energy and manure, the scheme seeks to create additional economic opportunities for farmers, supporting the transition from **“Annadatas” to “Urjadas.”**

Read More: [Compressed Biogas and India's Energy Security](#)

Birth Anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi and Shri Lal Bahadur Shastri



Source: PIB

Why in News?

On 2nd October 2026, India paid tributes to **Mahatma Gandhi** and former **Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri** on their birth anniversaries.

What are the Key Facts About Mahatma Gandhi?

- **Early Life & Formative Years:** Born on **2nd October 1869 at Porbandar** , he studied law in England (1888–91). His political and moral awakening was catalyzed in **1893** by racial humiliation at **Pietermaritzburg, South Africa** .
- **South African Initiatives:** He founded the **Natal Indian Congress (1894)** , published the ***Indian Opinion*** newspaper, and established the **Phoenix Settlement (1904)** and **Tolstoy Farm (1910)** , which served as foundational grounds for developing **Satyagraha (non-violent resistance)** .
- **Return to India:** Gandhi returned to India on **9th January 1915** , a date now commemorated as **Pravasi Bharatiya Diwas** , and subsequently established the **Sabarmati Ashram (1917)** to institutionalize his principles of truth and self-reliance.
- **Core Ideology:** His philosophy was rooted in *Satyagraha* (truth-force) and *Ahimsa* (non-violence). He believed that means must justify the ends.
- **Major Political Movements:** His pan-India leadership began with the **Champaran Satyagraha (1917)** and **Kheda Satyagraha (1918)** , followed by the **Rowlatt Satyagraha (1919)** .
 - He subsequently led mass nationalist campaigns including the **Non-Cooperation Movement (1920–22)** , the **Civil Disobedience Movement via the Dandi March (1930)** , and the **Quit India Movement (1942)** .
- **Socio-Economic Reforms:** Championing the **Charkha** and **Khadi** as symbols of the dignity of labor and economic self-reliance, he founded the **All India Spinners' Association (1925)** and the **Harijan Sevak Sangh (1932)** to eradicate untouchability and foster communal harmony.
 - Beyond political independence, Gandhi championed the eradication of untouchability (Harijan upliftment), Hindu-Muslim unity, and village self-reliance (*Gram Swaraj*) through the promotion of Khadi and cottage industries.
- **Literary Contributions:** He articulated his critique of modern civilization and political vision in ***Hind Swaraj*** and detailed his moral journey in ***An Autobiography: The Story of My Experiments with Truth*** .
- **Global Recognition:** Assassinated on **30th January 1948** , his legacy of peace remains globally recognized, with the United Nations declaring **2nd October** as the **International Day of Non-Violence** .

Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi

“The weak can never forgive. Forgiveness is the attribute of the strong.”

Brief Description

Birth: 2nd October 1869, Porbandar (Gujarat).

2nd October is observed as **International Day of Non-Violence**.

Profile: Lawyer, Politician, Social activist, Writer and led Nationalist Movement.

Father of the Nation (first called by Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose).

Ideology: Believed in the ideas of non-violence, Truth, Honesty, Care for Mother Nature, Compassion, Welfare of Downtrodden etc.

Political Mentor: Gopal Krishna Gokhale

Death: Shot dead by Nathuram Godse (30th January, 1948).

30th January is observed as **Martyrs' Day**

Nominated for the Nobel Peace Prize five times.



Gandhi in South Africa (1893-1915)

Used satyagraha against racist regime (Native Africans and Indians were discriminated).

Pravasi Bharatiya Divas (PBD) is celebrated every year on 9th January, to commemorate his return from South Africa.

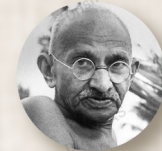
Contribution in India's Freedom Struggle

Small-scale movements like Champaran Satyagraha (1917)—First Civil Disobedience, Ahmedabad Mill Strike (1918)—First Hunger Strike, and Kheda Satyagraha (1918)—First Non-Cooperation.

Nationwide Mass Movements: Against Rowlatt Act (1919), Non-Cooperation Movement (1920-22), Civil Disobedience Movement (1930-34), Quit India Movement (1942).

Gandhi-Irwin Pact (1931): Between Gandhi and Lord Irwin that marked the end of a period of civil disobedience.

Poona Pact (1932): Between Gandhi and **B.R. Ambedkar**; this abandoned the idea of separate electorates for the depressed classes (Communal Award).



Books Written

Hind Swaraj, My Experiments with Truth (Autobiography)

Weeklies

Harijan, Navjivan, Young India, Indian Opinion.

Gandhi Peace Prize

is given by India for social, economic, and political transformation through Gandhian methods.

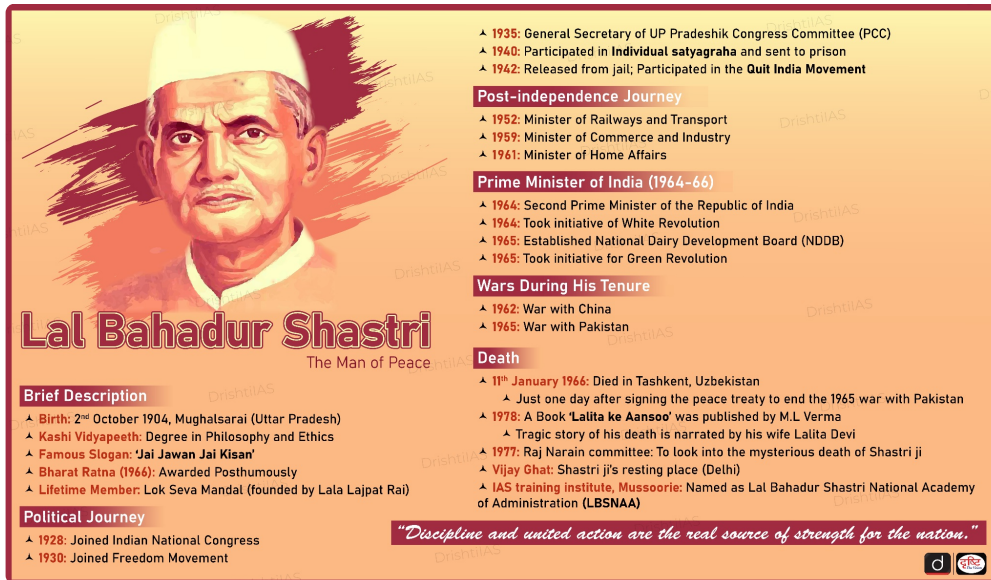
“Happiness is when what you think, what you say, and what you do are in harmony.”

“You must not lose faith in humanity. Humanity is an ocean; if a few drops of the ocean are dirty, the ocean does not become dirty.”

What are the Key Facts About Lal Bahadur Shastri?

- **Early Life:** Lal Bahadur Shastri, born on **2 nd October 1904 in Mughalsarai**, Uttar Pradesh.
 - He opposed the **caste system**, dropped the surname “**Srivastava**”, and earned the title “**Shastri**” from **Kashi Vidyapeeth** in 1926.
 - Inspired by **Mahatma Gandhi**, he joined the **Non-Cooperation Movement** at 16 and later rejected **dowry**, accepting only a **charkha and Khadi**.
 - He actively participated in the **Civil Disobedience Movement** and spent **over seven years in British prisons**.
- **Political Career:** Became Parliamentary Secretary (1946) and later Home Minister of Uttar Pradesh; held key Union portfolios including Railways, Transport & Communications, Commerce & Industry, and Home Affairs.
- **Accountability:** He resigned as Railway Minister in 1956, accepting moral responsibility for a train accident.

- He is known for integrity, humility and efficiency, and described as a “little dynamo of a man.”
- **Tenure as Prime Ministership:** Lal Bahadur Shastri succeeded **Jawaharlal Nehru** as Prime Minister and served from **1964-1966** .
- He laid the groundwork for the **Green Revolution** in India to boost food grain production. He also promoted the **White Revolution** (Operation Flood) by supporting the Amul milk co-operative in Gujarat and establishing the National Dairy Development Board.
- He led India during the **1965 Indo-Pak War** and gave the slogan “**Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan**” , highlighting the importance of **national security and food security** .
- He died in **Tashkent on 11 th January 1966** , shortly after signing the **Tashkent Declaration** .



Lal Bahadur Shastri
The Man of Peace

Brief Description

- ▲ Birth: 2nd October 1904, Mughalsarai (Uttar Pradesh)
- ▲ Kashi Vidyapeeth: Degree in Philosophy and Ethics
- ▲ Famous Slogan: 'Jai Jawan Jai Kisan'
- ▲ Bharat Ratna (1966): Awarded Posthumously
- ▲ Lifetime Member: Lok Seva Mandal (founded by Lala Lajpat Rai)

Political Journey

- ▲ 1928: Joined Indian National Congress
- ▲ 1930: Joined Freedom Movement

Post-independence Journey

- ▲ 1935: General Secretary of UP Pradeshik Congress Committee (PCC)
- ▲ 1940: Participated in Individual satyagraha and sent to prison
- ▲ 1942: Released from jail; Participated in the Quit India Movement

Prime Minister of India (1964-66)

- ▲ 1964: Second Prime Minister of the Republic of India
- ▲ 1964: Took initiative of White Revolution
- ▲ 1965: Established National Dairy Development Board (NDDB)
- ▲ 1965: Took initiative for Green Revolution

Wars During His Tenure

- ▲ 1962: War with China
- ▲ 1965: War with Pakistan

Death

- ▲ 11th January 1966: Died in Tashkent, Uzbekistan
- ▲ Just one day after signing the peace treaty to end the 1965 war with Pakistan
- ▲ 1978: A Book 'Lalita ke Aansoo' was published by M.L Verma
- ▲ Tragic story of his death is narrated by his wife Lalita Devi
- ▲ 1977: Raj Narain committee: To look into the mysterious death of Shastri ji
- ▲ Vijay Ghat: Shastri ji's resting place (Delhi)
- ▲ IAS training institute, Mussoorie: Named as Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration (LBSNAA)

"Discipline and united action are the real source of strength for the nation."

Note: On October 2nd , the death anniversary of former Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Kumaraswami Kamaraj (1903-1975) is observed.

- **Early Life & Freedom Struggle:** Born in **1903 in Tamil Nadu** , K. Kamaraj participated in the **Salt Satyagraha (1930)** and was jailed during the **Quit India Movement (1942)** . He was also elected to the **Constituent Assembly in 1946** .
- **Role in National Politics:** Often referred to as the "Kingmaker" in Indian politics. K. Kamaraj served as **Chief Minister of Madras State (1954-1963)** and later became **Congress President (1963)** .
 - His **Kamaraj Plan** encouraged senior leaders to leave ministerial posts and strengthen party organisation.
- **Education Reform:** Pioneered the **Mid-Day Meal Scheme** to improve school enrolment and reduce rural illiteracy. His birth anniversary is observed as **Education Development Day in Tamil Nadu** .
- **Legacy:** K. Kamaraj died in 1975 and was posthumously awarded the **Bharat Ratna** in 1976, India's highest civilian honour.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What were Gandhi's major principles of political action?

Satyagraha and Ahimsa formed the core of Gandhi's political philosophy, emphasising **truth, non-violence and ethical means** .

2. What is the significance of Gandhi's Champaran Satyagraha?

The **1917 Champaran Satyagraha** marked Gandhi's first major mass movement in India and addressed the exploitation of **indigo cultivators** .

3. What was the Kamaraj Plan?

Introduced in **1963** , it proposed that senior Congress ministers **resign from government posts and focus on strengthening party organisation** .

4. What did "Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan" signify?

Lal Bahadur Shastri's slogan highlighted the importance of **national security and food security** , particularly during the **1965 Indo-Pak War** .

5. What was Kamaraj's contribution to education?

As Madras Chief Minister, Kamaraj expanded **school education** and promoted the **Mid-Day Meal Scheme** to improve enrolment and reduce educational deprivation.

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Who among the following is associated with 'Songs from Prison', a translation of ancient India religious lyrics in English? (2021)

- (a) Bal Gangadhar Tilak
- (b) Jawaharlal Nehru
- (c) Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi
- (d) Sarojini Naidu

Ans: C

Q: With reference to the British colonial rule in India, consider the following statements: (2019)

1. Mahatma Gandhi was instrumental in the abolition of the system of 'indentured labour'.
2. In Lord Chelmsford's 'War Conference', Mahatma Gandhi did not support the resolution on recruiting Indians for World War.
3. Consequent upon the breaking of the Salt Law by the Indian people, the Indian National Congress was declared illegal by the colonial rulers.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 1 and 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: B

